

Lab 12 – Enhance the Leave Assistant with Knowledge Sources

Lab Overview

In **Lab 11**, you built a **Leave Assistant** that guided employees through common leave-related requests using **Topics**, **Questions**, **Variables**, and **Conditional Logic**.

While this approach works well for structured business processes, it is not practical to create a separate topic for every employee question. Modern AI assistants can answer informational questions by searching trusted knowledge sources such as company policies, employee handbooks, SharePoint sites, and internal websites.

In this lab, you will **enhance your existing Leave Assistant** by adding **Knowledge Sources**. This enables the assistant to answer a wider range of HR questions using **Generative Answers**, without creating additional topics.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lab, you will be able to:

- Enhance an existing Copilot with Knowledge Sources.
 - Add websites or documents as organizational knowledge.
 - Configure Generative Answers.
 - Test natural language questions.
 - Understand when to use **Topics** and when to use **Knowledge Sources**.
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Business Scenario

The HR team is pleased with the Leave Assistant created in the previous lab. Employees can already:

- Apply for Leave
- Check Leave Balance
- View Leave Information

However, employees also ask many policy-related questions such as:

- How many annual leave days do employees receive?
- Can unused leave be carried forward?
- What is the maternity leave policy?
- How do I apply for paternity leave?

Instead of creating separate topics for every question, the HR team wants the assistant to answer these questions directly from trusted HR documents.

Expected Conversation

Structured Request (Topic)

Employee

I need help with leave.

Copilot

How can I help you today?

- Apply for Leave
 - Check Leave Balance
 - Leave Policy Information
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Informational Question (Knowledge)

Employee

Can I carry forward my unused leave?

Copilot

The Leave Policy states that employees may carry forward up to the permitted number of unused leave days into the next calendar year, subject to company policy.

Another Question

Employee

What is the maternity leave policy?

Copilot

The Employee Leave Policy describes the eligibility criteria, duration, and approval process for maternity leave.

Task 1 – Open the Leave Assistant

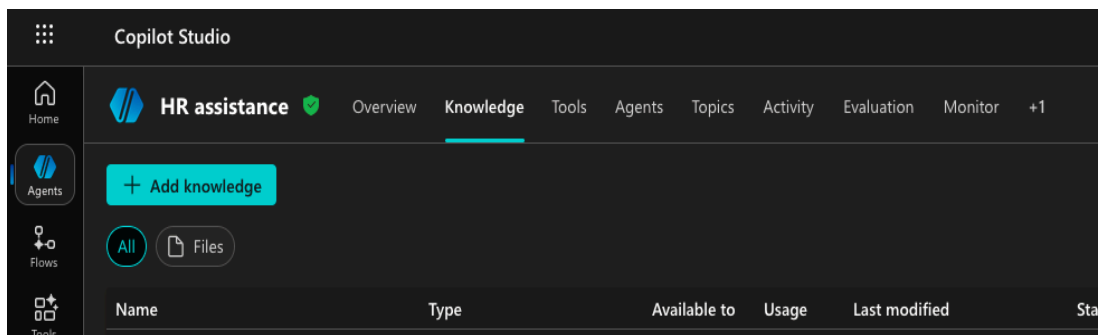
1. Open **Microsoft Copilot Studio**.
 2. Select your training environment.
 3. Open the **Leave Assistant** created in **Lab 11**.
 4. Verify that the topic is working by testing one leave-related conversation.
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Expected Outcome

The Leave Assistant is open and ready to be enhanced.

Task 2 – Add a Knowledge Source

1. From the left navigation pane, select **Knowledge**.
2. Select **+ Add knowledge**.



The latest Copilot Studio supports multiple knowledge sources, including:

- Website
- File (PDF, Word, etc.)

- SharePoint
- Dataverse (if configured)

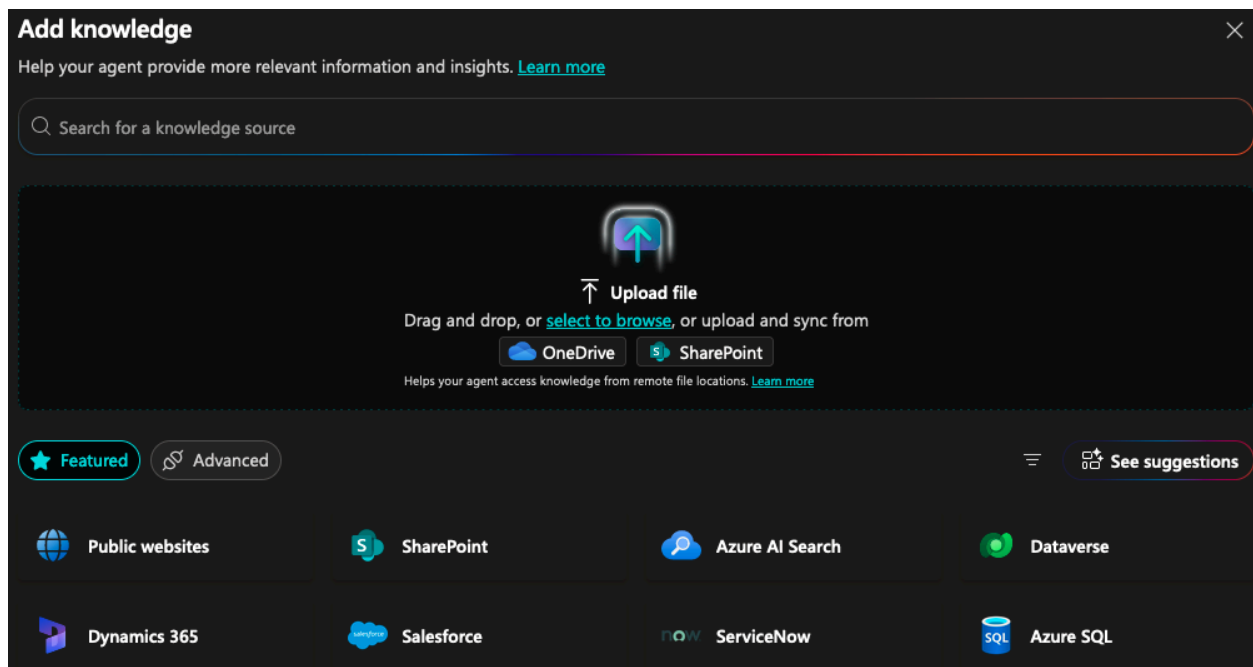
For this lab, choose one of the following:

- **Website** (recommended for all learners)
- **File** (if an HR policy document is provided)

Expected Outcome

The **Add knowledge** panel opens.

Task 3 – Configure the Knowledge Source



Option A – Website (Recommended)

You can use this HR policies website, enter the URL:

<https://hrmssoftwareinindia.com/hr-policies/>

Or you can use any trusted public source related to HR or Microsoft documentation.

Select **Add**.

Option B – File

Upload the HR Leave Policy PDF:

1. Select **File**.
2. Upload the document.
3. Wait for the upload to complete.

Important (Latest Copilot Studio)

- **Knowledge sources must complete indexing before they can answer questions.**
- Depending on the size of the content, indexing may take a few minutes.

Expected Outcome

The knowledge source appears with a **Ready** or **Indexed** status.

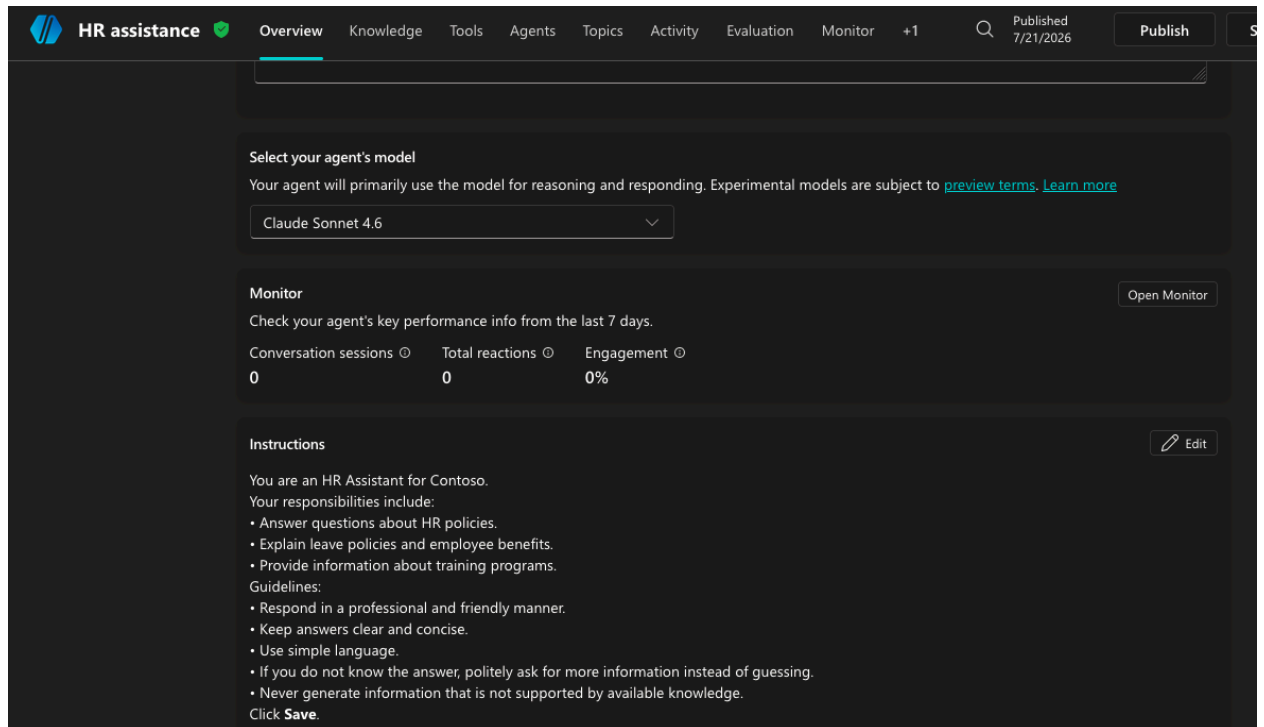
Task 4 – Review the Agent Instructions

Open the agent's **Overview** (or **Settings**, depending on your environment).

Review the agent instructions.

For example:

You are a Leave Assistant that helps employees with leave-related requests. Use the configured knowledge sources to answer policy-related questions. If the answer is not available, politely inform the user.

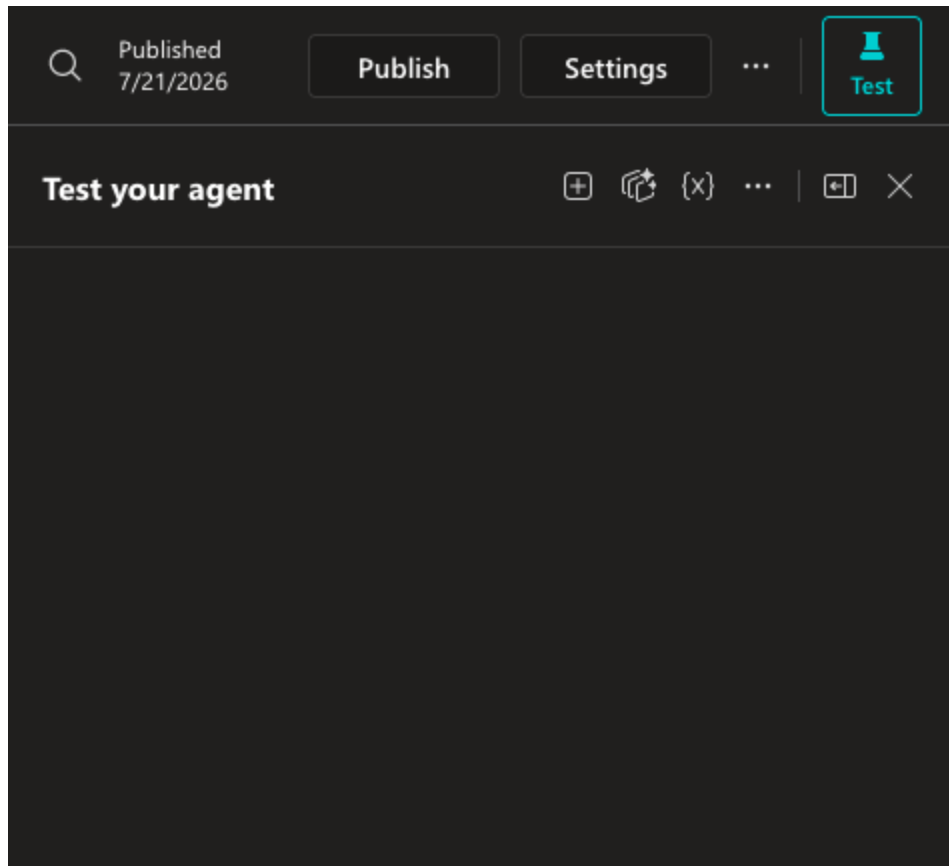


Expected Outcome

The assistant is configured to use its knowledge sources when generating responses.

Task 5 – Test Generative Answers

Open **Test your agent**.



Ask questions that are answered by your configured knowledge source.

Examples:

- What is the annual leave policy?
- Can unused leave be carried forward?
- How do I apply for maternity leave?
- What documents are required for sick leave?

Observe how the assistant generates answers from the configured knowledge.

Important

These questions are answered using **Knowledge Sources**.

You are **not** creating:

- New Topics
- Trigger Phrases

- Conditions
- Variables

The assistant searches the indexed knowledge and generates the response automatically.

Expected Outcome

The assistant provides answers based on the configured knowledge.

Task 6 – Compare Topics and Knowledge

Test the following two scenarios.

Scenario 1 – Structured Business Process

User

I want to apply for leave.

Expected Result

The assistant follows the **Topic** created in Lab 11 and guides the employee through the structured leave process.

Scenario 2 – Informational Question

User

What is the maternity leave policy?

Expected Result

The assistant answers using the configured **Knowledge Source** instead of following a topic.

Discussion

Notice the difference:

User Request	Handled By
Apply for Leave	Topic
Check Leave Balance	Topic
Leave Policy Questions	Knowledge Source
HR Policy Questions	Knowledge Source